

Persepolis

The ceremonial capital of the First Persian Empire, now a cluster of ruined palaces

Located in modern-day Iran, the remains at Persepolis conjure up the glory of the Achaemenid kings. This great dynasty ruled the First Persian Empire in c.550–330 BCE, while Persepolis itself was founded by Darius I in c.518 BCE.

Persepolis seems to have been used only during certain festivals. Its main features—a massive gateway, the palatial Audience Hall, and the gigantic Throne Hall (“the Hundred-Column Hall”)—were meant to impress. The sculpted reliefs of foreign dignitaries bearing gifts for the king, and the presence of a substantial treasury, have led to suggestions that tribute money was paid here. The mud-brick walls and roofs of Persepolis are gone, but many of the stone columns are still standing, often with elaborate, animal-shaped capitals.

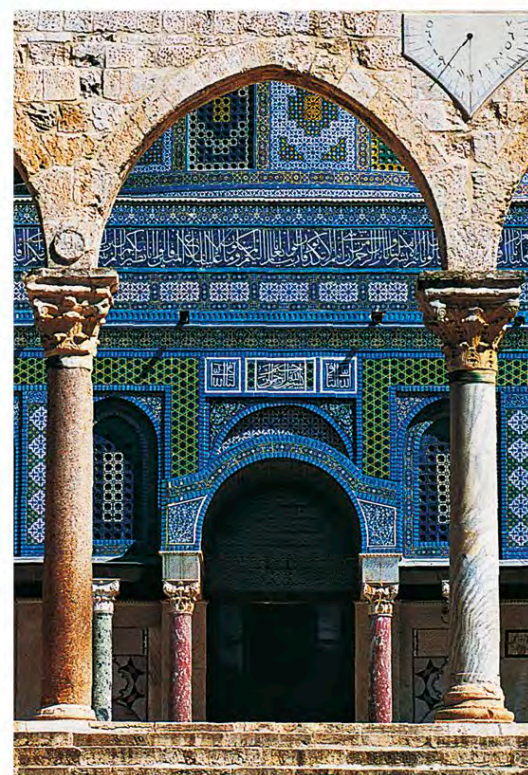
▽ GATE OF ALL NATIONS

Part-man, part-bull, part-bird, this powerful figure is a *lamassu*—a guardian deity, which stood at the Gate of All Nations, a portal through which visitors to the royal palaces would have passed.



▷ TILED FACADE

The blue-and-white coloring of the İznik tiles (made in İznik in western Anatolia) is one of the highlights of the building's exterior. Added in the 16th century, the tiles survived until the 1960s, when most were replaced with replicas.



▽ GILDED DOME

The 66-ft- (20-m-) wide dome was originally made of gold but was later replaced with copper and then aluminum. It was re-covered with gold leaf under King Hussein of Jordan (r.1952-1999).

